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Mr EARTH: Al Gore's lectures created a climate for change

mitigate it. The IPCC does not carry out research but instead engages 600 direct authors, many of them Nobel Laureates, along with 2,500 others to prepare assessment reports. "All this comes at a bargain price for the earth," says Pachauri.

Pachauri's skill lay in orchestrating the entire effort, ensuring that the organisation remained focused and that the credibility of its assessment reports remained high. Kapil Sibal, Union Minister of Science and Technology says: "We applaud the work of the IPCC and the entire scientific community it represents. We are proud too of Pachauri for being a global citizen and standing up for the right cause."

In the past year or so, the panel has brought out some stunning reports confirming that the earth's temperature has risen to an alarmingly high level in recent history and that we could only ignore the warning signs at our peril. In doing so, the IPCC report ended decades of dispute over the existence of climate change itself. The IPCC reports and Gore's riveting lectures on "the inconvenient truths" created a whole new awareness about the

debilitating effects of global warming. They goaded recalcitrant nations like the US to begin to make commitments on reducing their emissions of greenhouse gases (GHG). Most importantly it brought about a climate for change.

It is another matter though that despite their pioneering efforts, most nations are yet to fulfil their commitments to bringing down their own emission levels. Pachauri is exasperated by such dithering and says that "the record has been poor internationally." Developed countries had taken up obligations under the Kyoto Protocol to reduce their emission levels, but most have defaulted. The US, the world's biggest GHG emitter, is also the worst culprit. Pachauri has been pushing for "a workable timetable for action" among these countries for a new protocol that will come into effect in 2012.

While Gore has been a tireless global campaigner, Pachauri has done more than his own bit for the cause. As Director General of the Delhi-based The

Energy and Resources Institute (TERI), an institution he has headed for over 25 years, Pachauri has worked to not only come up with hard data but also provide workable solutions to energy and environmental problems.

India has produced a host of environmental activists who have made their mark. In the seventies, it was the Chipko movement that showed the way against deforestation. In the eighties, Medha Patkar pushed the world to reconsider the benefits of large dams. In the nineties, Vandana Shiva took on the battle against genetically modified foods and Ashok Khosla provided low tech development alternatives. Meanwhile, wildlife activists like Valmik Thapar fought to save the tiger from extinction. At the turn of the century, Sunita Narain successfully took on the soft drink giants on pollution.

All through Pachauri remained in the limelight carving a niche for himself. Rather than adopt a confrontational approach, he actively collaborated with the government in bringing about a change. His networking skills saw TERI seminars rope in the best speakers in the world. An engineer and energy economist of repute, Pachauri believes that at the centre of the solution is the individual himself. "We are already living well beyond the earth's means. Yet people will not think twice before driving down to buy a loaf of bread. We need major behavioural changes."

Though under the Kyoto Protocol, developing countries like India are exempt from mandatory reduction in greenhouse gases, Pachauri believes that the nation can't be complacent. Among them are "no regret measures" like improving public transport, making buildings more energy efficient apart from moving towards greater use of renewable energy.

Pachauri warns that worldwide the impact of climate change is setting in so rapidly that the window of opportunity to do something about it has shortened considerably. As he says: It is either Now or Never.

Pachauri wants India to take 'no regrets' steps like improving public transport and constructing green buildings.